



SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

What is different about this World Championships compared to previous ones?

We are proud to have a Mondotrack not just in the competition area but also the warm-up area — something no World Championships has had before. Another major step was ensuring that the stadium, not just the playing field, is para-friendly. There are para-athletes with different levels of disability, including some who are permanently in wheelchairs. We have had most of the toilets at JLN adapted for wheelchair users. I can say that Nehru Stadium is becoming a 100% para-friendly venue.

What about spectators — are there any arrangements for fans?

We have been lucky because whatever the PCI suggested was accepted by the Ministry of Sport. We expect a few hundred wheelchair users to come and watch the competition. A dedicated zone has been made for them. It's important to look out for differently abled spectators. Many people will come

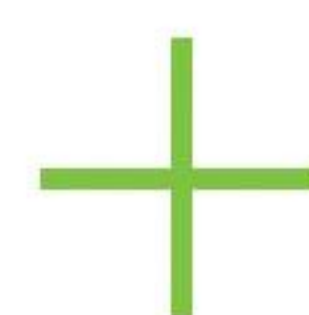
and watch the competition and think, 'We can do this as well.' A lot of them might have only seen para sport on social media, so we had to make proper arrangements for them.

This is just for Nehru Stadium. What about facilities at other venues?

This is only the beginning. This competition will be like a festival, and many administrators will come to see it. When they see how accessible JLN Stadium has become for para-athletes, they will think, 'Why can't we do this as well?'

We are already seeing other venues built with para sports in mind. If you visit the Sports Authority of India complex in Gandhinagar, Gujarat, you will see it is a para-friendly training centre, purpose-built for para-athletes. Training centres are also being developed in Sonapat and Bengaluru, and those too are para-friendly.

I also think it's important that TOPS funding has increased for para-athletes. The scheme provides



World Para Athletics Championships 2025 – Key Facts Edition: 12th World Para Athletics Championships

Flag bearers: Dharambir Nain (club throw gold, Paris 2024) & Preethi Pal (double bronze, sprint, Paris 2024)

Indian squad: 73 athletes in total, including 19 women

Asia hosts so far: Doha 2015, Dubai 2019, Kobe 2024, New Delhi 2025

India's best finish: Top six for the first time in Kobe 2024

not just financial support but also freedom. If a player says, 'I want to train with this coach, or I need this physiotherapist, or I want to train abroad,' they have that freedom. The player is the hero. There's also a kind of mental freedom. Even if a player receives ₹50,000 as pocket money, they feel mentally secure.

What do you hope the conclusion of this competition will show?

When I used to go to the ground, people used to make fun of me. They'd ask what I hoped to achieve. Tomorrow, when 107 countries come to compete here, what bigger statement could there be about how far we have progressed? This is a big thing for the country and certainly for me. I never thought in my life that there would be so much change in India. With India bidding for the 2030 Commonwealth Games and the 2036 Olympics, I hope these World Championships will show that we can host major tournaments.

What about after the World Championships? India has a problem where facilities often aren't maintained.

The track and facilities at JLN aren't just for these Games. Our real target is Los Angeles 2028. Earlier, athletes had to train abroad on a Mondo track. Now they can prepare here. This is a long-term plan, not just a one-off.